

## Decide What You Want to Achieve

Setting goals is as simple as deciding what you want and mapping out a plan for getting it. Many people focus on paying their monthly bills at the expense of their short- and long-term goals. Monthly bills have a way of expanding to use all your available money, making planning for the future a moot point. If you live beyond your means by using credit, or if you live paycheck to paycheck with nothing left over to save or invest, you'll never get ahead.

### Go for the Goal

Think seriously about what you want to achieve. Do you envision retiring while you're still young enough to enjoy travel or an active lifestyle? Would you like to buy your first home or move up to a larger home in a better neighborhood? In the shorter term, maybe a new car or a boat is on your wish list. If your short-term liabilities (due in a year or less) are greater than your current assets (cash and cash equivalents), paying down credit card debt may be your first priority. What's important to you?

Don't choose goals just because they sound like what you should want. The question is, do you want them badly enough to give up the instant gratification of spending all your money now for the future enjoyment of having what is really meaningful to you later?



Don't let fear of failure cause you to set goals that aren't ambitious enough. You want to stretch yourself a little to reach your goal, but you have to believe that it's possible or you won't stay motivated for long. Try to strike a balance.

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